regional commands and Jaffna, a system which many claim is a primary reason for the LTTE's centralised coordination, discipline and effectiveness. The regional commanders establish and maintain their authority

by means of strict control of all munitions and supplies distributed through the LTTE structure. Sub-regional commanders have guns, ammo, and other supplies doled out to them by the regional commanders. One Police contact claimed that the substantial ransom collections made by the LTTE are all immediately sent back to Jaffna for later distribution for the whole organisation as Prabhakaran sees fit. Everyone is required to take an oath of allegiance to Prabhakaran. The regional leaders are handpicked by Prabhakaran himself on the basis of trust, loyalty and experience.

Faridi explained how the R&AW balanced India's need to support both the Tamil insurgents and the Sri Lankan government. 'We provided the LTTE with missiles like the SA-7 just before the peace accord was signed, but avoided arming them with more sophisticated weapons,' he said. 'However, we received regular intelligence inputs that LTTE assets abroad had managed to establish links with the international arms market to procure advanced weaponry. At one point in 1986 we received real time intelligence that arms dealers with links to the Soviet Union were supplying weapons to the eastern provinces. It was actionable intelligence, but we took a conscious decision to keep alive the illegal supply route

to maintain balance as the Sri Lankan air force had increased attacks on LTTE's suspected armouries and the ultras were desperate to retaliate.'